THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION

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MINI-NEWSLETTER - JULY 2014

Chairman's Report

At the approach of the holiday period it is right to reflect on all the dramatic events of the last few weeks. We will all have been stirred and excited by the State Visit to France of H.M. The Queen and H.R.H. The Duke of Edinburgh. We will all have our own personal memories of that visit - the fine weather with which we were blessed in a summer which has been particularly fickle, and the impact the Queen made on her French hosts. "La Reine Superstar" as the Paris Match announces on the cover of the edition which reported on her visit in words and pictures. In every photograph the Queen is radiant and clearly very happy to be in France on her fifth State Visit.

Alongside those happy moments she experienced, as we all did, the special sombre mood on D-Day. Many will have seen the ceremonies on television. Indeed they will have seen more than those of us from the Paris Branch who made the visit to the British ceremony at Bayeux. What a pity that in these days of mass communication regional accents are becoming homogenized. But there in the beautiful Commonwealth War Graves Cemetery one heard from the older people all the rich accents of the British Isles, all assembled in one place. We experienced that once before, at a ceremony on 1st July commemorating the fallen in the Battle of the Somme, just as it would have been in 1916, when most of the Scottish, Irish and county regiments were engaged. At Bayeux we came away with a series of sounds and images which will be indelibly imprinted on our memory. We recall an endless stream of veterans approaching the central area where the ceremony was conducted. Some walking, many with sticks, many in wheel-chairs pushed by grand-children or by a uniformed officer of one of the three services. There was little conversation; they and all the families and spectators were immersed in the emotion of the occasion, and of course the veterans were reliving in their memory events of 70 years before to the day. Occasionally there would be a ripple of applause as heavily medalled veterans passed by. After the ceremony we saw the beautiful Poppy wreath laid at the foot of the cross by H.M. the Queen, and a striking wreath in white flowers laid by the Prince of Wales in the shape of the three plumes of his heraldic coat of arms. The father of one member of our party had landed in Normandy in 1944, and he will have very special memories of our visit. As he reported to us his father landed and then liberated a French lady who would become our member's mother!

Back in Paris in the evening, the Queen attended a State Dinner at the Elysée Palace. She addressed the 220 guests alternating French and English, paragraph by paragraph. Her very stirring, moving speech is attached to this Newsletter.

We attach overleaf the latest "For Your Diary" item, in the hope that as many Branch members as possible will come to the Arc de Triomphe on 4th August to commemorate the Centenary of that fateful day in 1914 when Britain and the Empire declared war alongside our French allies.

"We will remember them"

FOR YOUR DIARY

Date	Event	Venue
2nd August	Traditional Pre-Arc Committee Dinner	Feucherolles Golf Club (Yvelines)
	All Branch members are invited to join the Committee at this traditional event. The cost for a three-course Dinner, including Wine and Coffee is 36€ per head. There will be musical contribution from a harp, and Joan will later lead us in community singing as only she knows how. Sign up, with your cheque for a deposit of 50% (18€ made out to "Mlle Joan Hicks") and send it by post to her at: 6, rue des Petits Prés, 78810 Feucherolles. Her telephone: 01.30;54.33;06 e-mail: joan.hicks@orange.fr. Paris-based members without transport should signal that to Joan, who will then arrange a minibus A/R place de l'Etoile in Paris.	
4th August	Ravivage de la Flamme	Sous l'Arc de Triomphe
	We assemble under the Arc by 6.15 p.m. at the latest. Access via the Tunnel near the RER exit at the top of the avenue des Champs Elysées; Members who wish to join in the march behind our Standards should be at the same RER exit by 6 p.m. at the latest. We tradionally give a Reception in the Clubhouse afterwards, starting at 7.30p.m.	
7th September	RBL Pedal to Paris Arrival*	Arc de Triomphe
	We await details from London, but the cyclists usually arrive around 3.15 p.m., followed by a wreath-laying ceremony under the Arc de Triomphe.	
19th September	Bennecourt and Coldstream Guards Ravivage de la Flamme	Arc de Triomphe
	Branch Committee member Didier Dumont, Maire de Bennecourt will rekindle the Flamme with the Coldstream Guards who liberated the town in 1944.	
20th September	Coldstream Guards Bike ride	Bennecourt (Yvelines)
	Full details below. Our Union Flag and the Branch standard will be paraded	
25th September	Branch Committee Meeting	Clubhouse
16th October	Branch Committee	Clubhouse
28th October	Poppy Coffee Morning*	Ambassador's Residence
11th November	Commonwealth Service of Remembrance	Notre Dame Cathedral
11thNovember	Cenotaph Service	Whitehall, London
Anyone wishing take part in the march-past contact Janet Warby soonest		
20th November	Branch Committee Meeting	Clubhouse
8th December	Branch AGM*	Clubhouse
15th December	Christmas Lunch*	Clubhouse

*Details to follow later

Details of the day at Bennecourt:

We are the guests of RBL Committee member Didier Dumont, who is the Maire of Bennecourt (Yvelines). It will be a long day of events and those wishing to attend should bring a picnic lunch with them. Here is the full programme. Members may only wish to attend one or two key events, and of course they are perfectly free to cherry-pick in that way.

9.15 a.m.	VIP's welcomed by M. Le Maire
10.00 a.m.	Cyclists arrive from London
10.45 a.m.	Ceremony of Commemoration at the War memorial
11.45 a.m.	Inauguration of "Exposition du Centenaire" at the Médiathèque
12.45 p.m.	Vin d'Honneur at the Mairie
1.15 p.m.	Picnic lunch
2.45 p.m.	Colours and Band march to Eglise Saint Ouen
3.00 p.m.	Mass in Church

See next page for the Queen's speech.
Voir la page suivante pour le discours de la Reine.